

KF21 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This month we are learning about the self-hate experience. Self-hate is the product of the condemning judgments that we make when we fail to achieve our idealized standards. It brings to consciousness the deep judgments that we carry with us all the time. However, regardless of the pain that self-hate causes, self-hate is not our enemy. The real enemy is the Idol Self. This Idol depends on the fear of scathing judgment to lash us into submission and to maintain its pride system. But if you walk courageously through the valley of the shadow of death, working with your tools, you will drain the stagnant storage tank of self-condemnation and judgment that fuels your self-hate. The awareness of self-hate will become an invitation for exploration rather than the paralyzing, excruciating torment that you have experienced in the past.

For the last few months, we have been training our minds to observe what is within us, bubbling up from the depths of our souls. This month we will practice observing those bubbles, the evidence of our weaknesses and strengths, without getting caught up in the feelings, motivations, and behaviors of self-hate. With training, we learn to step back from self-hate, choose life, give a blessing, fortify our True Self, and strengthen our connection with God.

The Self-Hate Massage

Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Bring to mind an area of your life that chronically stirs up self-hate for you. Perhaps you have made a mistake, or perhaps your limitations are preventing you from achieving your dreams and goals. Something in your life may be imperfect, or you might fear that you are not good enough. Perhaps you have challenged your Idol Self in some way. We will connect that hurt to our breathing and get acquainted with it using our KF tools.

CONSIDER

Take a moment to collect yourself within your present space. Feel the air or the clothing on your skin. Notice any noises. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Now consider this area of self-hate. Notice the discomfort you feel when you think of it. Even though you hate this thing, allow it to rest inside your skin for one minute, without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

COMPASSION

As you breathe, experience yourself as a creature with limitations breathing in a material world. *(Pause)* You are not a god. *(Pause)* As you breathe in and out, imagine your area of self-hate moving in and out with the breath, massaging the place in your soul that is stuck or cramped. For one minute, give it and receive it with compassion. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

CLEANSE

Notice your entire body as it breathes. *(Pause)* Breathe with your mind, body, and soul as you open the doors of the prison cells of your shame, rage, disappointments, and guilt. *(Pause)* Allow the clean air to sweep through those dark, stagnant places for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause.

Our hymn for this confession is *My Faith Looks Up to Thee*:

While life's dark maze I tread,
And griefs around me spread,
Be Thou my guide;
Bid darkness turn to day,
Wipe sorrow's tears away,
Nor let me ever stray
From Thee aside.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

KF Confession 5 reminds us that our self-hate is a tragic and colossal waste of glory and potential:

We attacked and cruelly suppressed our True Self and lost our true life.

The Idol's system is like a fascist regime that suppresses the real power of the people. The word *suppressed* reminds us that beneath the Idol's system there is another power at work—a power that we can access to free ourselves from the Idol and actualize our potential.

I would like to summarize what we learned last week about self-hate.

1. Self-hate is irrational

When we are in self-hate, we experience compelling feelings that force us to do destructive things. This is why we cannot use logic or willpower to deal with self-hate. If we try to apply reason to self-hate, we will find ourselves groping around for a story that we hope will give us some certainty or comfort.

2. Self-hate is valuable

Self-hate is a big red flag that lets us know that we are living out of the Idol's pride system.

3. We have two choices when dealing with self-hate

We can appease self-hate, like sacrificing to an idol, or we can grow out of it. Appeasing is just running away. Some run away by punishing, accusing, or trying to control; some run away by suppressing their own reality; and others push back, shut down, or go numb.

4. Appeasing self-hate leads to an increasingly restricted life

In our efforts to appease our self-hate, we find ourselves avoiding people and situations that might trigger self-hate. We resist training opportunities because we loathe ourselves when we are confronted with our real limitations and weaknesses. More of these opportunities pile up as each day passes, and our fear and self-hate increases. We become more and more vulnerable, reactive, and anxious.

All tyrants use fear to control others and our inner tyrant, the Idol, is no different. It uses the fear of hurt pride and self-condemnation to control us. Fear is the strongest motivator that most of us know, and we have learned to turn it to a dubious advantage. Fear keeps us moving. It forces us to take action, and depending on our neurotic development, we habitually fight or flee when events trigger our fear.

Through fight or flight, we create the illusion that we are doing something about our fear. I believe that this is how phobias and taboos develop. We are already terrified, and we need to tell a story about the fear. My husband and I call this *Pin the Phobia on the Donkey*. What we mean is that we are chronically fearful but don't know why. We are blindfolded and confused. On the wall is a donkey made up of a collage of stories. Holding the tail of fear in our hands, we march up to the donkey and pin our tail of fear somewhere—anywhere. These stories include common phobias like the fear of heights, the fear of snakes and spiders, or the fear of water, but we can also fear and compulsively avoid exertion or rest, loneliness, self-examination, or any situation where we might feel helpless. We can develop phobias about another person, a job, or an activity. The illusion that we can identify our fear and pin it down gives us a feeling of security. Armed with a story about why we are as we are, we can avoid examining and dealing with the real cause of our distress.

A mastery person was proud of his imagined sense of justice. He enjoyed winning and felt justified in punishing others. Whenever he showed mercy to someone, he hated himself, so he would regularly flee from opportunities to be merciful and retreat into his habitual patterns of aggression. He had a taboo against showing mercy, even toward himself. He was more terrified of his self-hate than he was of the damage he caused by attacking.

A resigned woman felt the terror of self-hate whenever an event revealed her inner conflicts and her need for self-development. She had a taboo against making changes in her life and was proud of her imagined ability to detach from her feelings. Whenever she was presented with an invitation to grow, she would flee by shutting down.

The strange thing about our relationship with self-hate is that we fear it and need it at the same time. So, although we fear the damaging effects of self-hate, we often actively do things to keep our self-hate alive. We need self-hate to keep us moving toward our imagined glory; we cannot afford to let something die that spurs us on. To keep our self-hate alive, we hurt others and ourselves, neglect our training and our rest, fumble our jobs and our relationships, and revert to addictive, compulsive behaviors. We then concoct a story that focuses on these misoriented choices, but this story is actually a smokescreen that obscures our understanding of the real problem, which is our Idol's hurt pride.

When we make the judgment that our choices and “mistakes” fall short of our imagined standards of perfection, our pride is wounded, and we then hate ourselves and often despise anything or anyone connected to us. Our self-hate invites self-torment, and we punish ourselves with degrading and destructive thoughts, feelings, and actions. The fear of self-torment becomes a powerful motivator that relentlessly drives us to work harder to achieve our Idol’s impossible and ever-shifting standards. This fear also compels us to ruthlessly coerce those around us to vicariously fulfill our shoulds. Unfortunately, and inevitably, we meet with more “failure” and end up crippled with more self-hate as we try to force ourselves beyond our limitations and created design.

How do we manage ourselves when we are in the grip of self-hate and confused by our behavior, feelings, and thoughts? We can use worksheets, interventions, and other KF tools, and we can attend KF meetings. Sharing with others about our self-hate and listening to their experiences diffuses the power of these attacks. Record your self-hate experiences on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**. Notice how you react less often with self-hate as you continue with your training. Many KF members look back at their guides and see that over time an issue of self-hate has melted away without any direct effort to change it. Self-hate issues melt away because we are moving away from the Idol’s system.

Here are some other suggestions that might help you compassionately identify and manage your self-hate:

1. Look at your lists

Review the **Love or Pride?** list. Does it reveal something about your choices? Compare your behavior with Paul’s description of the Fruit of the Spirit.² Ask yourself, “Am I choosing to live in love, joy, peace, and the other characteristics of the Spirit?” Look at the list of the Beatitudes in Matthew 7. Compare what you want with what you have. Then, no matter how you feel, choose to take responsibility for the quality of your life. Train hard and make the fight with your Idol Self easy.

2. Review Dr. Horney’s book

Continue to explore *Neurosis and Human Growth* looking for insights into self-hate.³ Make a list of areas that could be self-hate hotspots for you.

3. Write a letter of compassion to yourself

What would you say to encourage a friend who is in self-hate? What would encourage you? Write down your thoughts in a letter of encouragement to yourself and keep this letter in your KF notebook. When you begin to break free, your Idol will invariably use self-hate as a whip to force you back into line and suppress any efforts you might make toward your healing. So, in this letter, remind yourself that we often experience self-hate when we refuse to comply with our Idol.

4. Talk to your Karis Link

Hopefully, your Karis Link has learned some tips for managing self-hate. You might ask them to do a KF worksheet with you. Together, consider and appreciate the progress you have made since joining Karis Fellowships.

5. Talk to someone who can help you reconnect to reality

This person can be anyone, a professional or just someone wise, who can give you a “reality check” and point you back to the Believe It Path. Self-hate is largely the product of illusions. A reality check reminds you of what is true, what is real, and what is your business. If I were a guinea hen in a barnyard

and hated myself because I couldn't swim, it would be nice to have someone remind me that even though I want to swim like a duck, I am not a duck. Talk to someone who can help you get real.

6. In the midst of your misery, remember to pray

If you are training hard, ask God to give you an encouraging present or gift. Watch for His care and then return to Him a gift of gratitude. God's mercy is greater than your self-hate.

7. Make a gratitude list

Write down the things for which you are thankful. Gratitude creates soothing endorphin chemistry that helps your mind and body return to the Christian reality of positive hope.⁴

8. Mindfully breathe

Learn to respond to self-hate with mindful breathing, connecting to your body and to God.

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Shepherd, what does my self-hate reveal to You about me? What can it reveal to me about You?
(Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

We are our own worst enemy. Let's stop blaming others or our circumstances and acknowledge that the real enemy is ourselves.

Listen again to KF Confession 5:

We attacked and cruelly suppressed our True Self and lost our true life.

Last week we began looking at Psalm 23 from a KF perspective. If you have never memorized this psalm, you might spend a few minutes of your meditation time doing that mindful work. Post a copy of the psalm somewhere in the house or at work. Listen to it in the car or during your exercise routine. You might use music to help you remember the words.

Here is a summary of what we learned in our last lesson:

1. The Lord our Shepherd meets our real needs

Jesus said, "I am the good Shepherd."⁵ He provides the security and support that we need as we give up our Idol's law and pride system. If we will not give up our Idol's law and pride system for our own sake, we might do it for Jesus. Allow yourself to be motivated by the Person who created you, who cares about your True Self even if you do not, and who, like a great coach, can train you for your true potential and glory. We cannot do this simply through willpower, nor will legal systems lead us to our potential. We are personal creatures who need personal help. One size does not fit all. Just as children need compassionate and observant parents to guide them in life, we need a Person to help us grow.

2. It is Jesus who restores, or repairs, our soul

Our redeemed and alive soul is our True Self. Jesus created our soul and He knows how to repair it. He longs to have a relationship with us, so He is committed to helping us become the people He created us to be. Jesus hates all idols, including the Idol Self, because they are destructive, artificial, untrustworthy, and incapable of relationship. Real human beings in real relationships are productive and continually open doors to more real relationship. We were designed to engage in growing relationships, and in them we find our path to healing.

3. The Idol Self will not support the restoration of our soul

In order to survive and maintain its power, the Idol Self will resist any effort you make to restore your True Self. If you choose humility and freedom, the Idol will fiercely oppose your efforts using fear and self-hate as its weapons. You will enter the valley of the shadow of death. In KF, we learn to observe the valley and our fear, and we learn to courageously face the anticipated evil. This evil feels like death, but it is only a shadow. Because our Savior is leading us, we have the confidence to pass through the valley of our fear. We do not face the fear of death alone. We are in relationship with the One who has passed through death and conquered. He is asking us to do the same—to pass through death and conquer.

4. The Shepherd's rod and staff guide and help us

Secure in the Shepherd's care, we can refuse to be guided by our shoulds, taboos, and claims and, instead, learn to respond to His guidance. With skillful hands, the Shepherd uses His rod and staff to train, direct, and protect us, meeting our needs and responding to our choices. He tailors our training to what we reveal about ourselves and specifically attends to those who want to be trained. When we show ourselves to be trustworthy, He eagerly responds with provision and support. His desire is to train us to maintain the path of orientation, which leads to all the benefits of healthy development, growing trust, and expanding potential.

Now let's look at the last two verses of **Psalm 23**, which I have translated using some alternative vocabulary to help expand our understanding.

⁵You set in order before me a table with my particular limitations.

You have enriched my head with oil;

My cup overflows with abundance.

⁶Good things and kindnesses will follow after me all the days of my life,

And throughout my life I will return to the house of the Lord.

Take a deep breath.

Most of us have heard that the Lord prepares a table before us *in the presence of enemies*. According to Strong's Concordance, the Hebrew word for enemies also means a narrow place, or a binding, as in being tied up. There is a sense of distress and limitation as in a besieged city. To give you a more thorough understanding of this psalm, I have conveyed this idea of restriction by using the word *limitations*. When we meet with limitations, we often feel distressed, or under siege, because we perceive these limitations as obstacles to our happiness and satisfaction. Let's listen again to verse 5 in my translation: *You set in order before me a table with my particular limitations. (Repeat)* Your table is set with limitations that are uniquely yours. They are part of the abundance that is promised to you through the picture of the oil and the cup that overflows. How can that be?

Real limitations protect us. The Shepherd knows what we can handle at our present stage of development, and He uses real limitations to help protect us from what we cannot handle. When we mindfully accept what *is*, and courageously sit at the table ordered for *us*, our limitations become part of our strategy rather than the focus of our judgments. This oriented submission to reality invites us to work creatively within our limitations and discover our great potential.⁶

In misorientation, however, we can rarely imagine this potential. We lose sight of what could be and, in our egocentric judgment, become fixated on what *should be*. Our resentment and discontent cripple and blind us, and in the midst of our struggles we cannot see or access God's guidance and gifts. We gaze with admiration and wrath at the tables around us and feel cheated and inadequate. Our neurotic pride is in agony, and we rail against the unfairness of not having what others have. We imagine that if we could pick and possess the qualities we covet on the tables of others, we would be able to fulfill our imagined and idealized glory, ease our anxiety about our value, our roles, and our self-worth, and gain the trappings that would finally make us feel superior and special. In our self-hate, we loathe our real glory, the glory that God intends for us, and we resist any invitation to discover what our limitations might be offering. We fall into the snare of judging the table set before us and then find ourselves full of envy, resentment, and ingratitude.⁷

When we gaze at the tables of others, coveting their supposed benefits, our envy prevents us from recognizing that those tables are also full of limitations. This inability to recognize and accept the limitations of others reflects our inability to accept our own limitations. It is so much easier to envy than to accept, submit, and train. If we could learn to honor our real limitations and accept them as part of God's design, we would be able to respect the limitations of others; we would have the courage to invest and support rather than coerce, steal, or compete. What might be the outcome if when faced with the limitations of others, we offered the acceptance, interest, compassion, and gratitude that we would hope to receive?

How do we learn to recognize our real limitations designed for us by our Creator? We start by acknowledging that everyone's resources are limited, including our own. When we approach the end of those resources, we begin to suffer. This suffering indicates that we have met a limitation. Real limitations remind us that we are not gods with inexhaustible possibilities. They are an indication that we need help or that our thinking and choices have taken us into misorientation. It is often painful to accept that we are not what we imagine we should be, or could be, but are just creatures learning to respect the limitations of a material existence.

All human beings are material creatures that need to sleep, breathe, eat and eliminate, work and rest; and if you want to stay healthy, you need to do basic things like brush your teeth and take care of your body. You must also learn to live in a community and honor the boundaries that defend its values. All of these necessities are real limitations. Our pride system, however, hates material limitations because they undermine the Idol's search for glory. It is intolerable for us to admit that our illusions about who we are and what we can accomplish are simply neurotic ambition, and—to our great detriment—we refuse to let those illusions go. This refusal creates confusion about our real limitations and interferes with the development of our True Self.

Our individual design presents real limitations, such as the natural limitations inherent in being male or female or living in light skin or dark skin. Your energetic matrix in the creation, your mental capacities, your health, and your genetic heritage also present real limitations. These limitations are readily apparent when your observation isn't clouded by your pride system's preoccupation with what *should be*. Design

limitations are not who you are, however; they are simply on your table and presented to you as opportunities for training. As you work with these limitations, they are eventually woven into your mission. Design limitations train and prepare you, but they do not define you. When you begin to discover and honor the limitations of your material existence, you will be much closer to the reality of who you are—a child of God training your True Self to be an heir of His kingdom.

There are also limitations of training, education, geography, language, and culture. These are limitations that are imposed on us; they are not part of our design. Many of these limitations can be stretched or changed, but this work is very difficult because we have to give up our pride system. In order to do that, we will need strong CORE muscles and the courage to make productive but heart-rending choices. For example, if I wish to change the patterns that I learned when growing up, I must choose to look deeply at my hurt, rage, and fear and then follow a protocol that will help me retrain my old habits of thinking, feeling, and behaving. It is hard and scary work! Self-hate will stalk me at every turn, but through the process of training I will discover the truth about my limitations, what can or cannot be changed and what no longer works for me.

Real limitations are easy to recognize when we try new things or make new efforts. If we find that our efforts are not sustainable, we have run into a real or current limitation. These limitations often indicate that either we are trying to do something outside the flow of our design or we have not yet trained hard enough to stretch a particular limitation. When we come up against these impediments, we can stop, pray, and reconsider our training; we can slow down, break the training process into smaller steps, and work toward orientation and humility. A careful approach to each limitation prepares our soul for its next leap forward. Every new effort will feel uncomfortable for a time, so be prepared to get up, fall down, get up, try again—and discover what is possible.

The promise that goodness and kindnesses will follow us and that our home is with the Lord our Shepherd inspires us to courageously sit at our own table and stop looking around at other tables.

At this point, we might ask ourselves: *Do I want to leave a trail of goodness, health, and compassionate mercy behind me, or would I rather continue to work hard at actualizing my Idol Self? Do I want to face the realities of my present situation and discover the potential of my particular challenges and strengths, or am I only interested in my judgment of how things should be? Do I want to lay a trail of good that others can follow, or do I want to keep chasing the tail of the Idol Self? What do I want?*

What do you want?

Our prayer might go something like this:

Shepherd, I want to leave behind me a trail of goodness and kindnesses. Help me make that happen.
(Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water, and prepare to take a few notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider one of your present limitations. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

How does it feel when you *consider one of your present limitations*? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold in awareness your experience with this limitation. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. Sometimes we flush feelings and thoughts from our consciousness before they have a chance to teach us. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this limitation*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what frustration, unfairness, or self-condemnation feels like in your body. You might feel relief. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider one of your present limitations*. Do you feel compelled to judge this limitation as good or evil? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you make this judgment? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* How might your Idol's pride be hurt if you were to submit to this limitation? How might your True Self be liberated? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat to yourself the word *Welcome*.

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore your limitations.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit who wants to lead you to abundance.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁸

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I observe this limitation, I let go of the craving for power and control.
- As I observe this limitation, I let go of the craving for self-esteem and affection.
- As I observe this limitation, I let go of the craving for security and comfort.

- As I observe this limitation, I let go of the craving to escape my situation. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time of healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You continue to guide us to our real glory and to the truth of who you created us to be. With Your rod and staff, train us for the next step as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with the Creation and the community, and with You, for the honor and glory of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *My Faith Looks Up to Thee* by Ray Palmer (1808–1887).

² Gal. 5:22–23.

³ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁴ simplyfit4life.com/releasing-endorphins-no-its-not-a-disease.

⁵ John 10:11–16.

⁶ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Obstacle_Is_the_Way.

⁷ Psalm 69:22.

⁸ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.